Shrinking Women and Revenge of the Crazy Wimmin

By Lily Myers and Leah Harris

Maya Angelou once said: A wise woman wishes to be no one's enemy; [but] a wise woman refuses to be anyone's victim . . . You see, according to Leah Harris, "Words have the terrible power to dehumanize and destroy, but they also have the tremendous power to heal and rebuild that which has been destroyed."

INTRODUCTION

There is a pull in our society to mute a woman's voice until it coos. To control it. To silence it. And still, she speaks. She tries to be heard. But often her voice is ignored, or belittled, mocked, critiqued or shouted down. Should she speak up and risk being seen as "pushy," "opinionated," or God forbid . . . "a feminist?" Or does she accept the status quo, hold her tongue and simply "shrink?" Shrinking Women by Lily Myers

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Shrinking Women

Across from me at the kitchen table, my mother smiles
over red wine that she drinks out of a measuring
glass.
She says she doesn't deprive herself,
but I've learned to find nuance in every movement of her
fork.
In every crinkle in her brow as she offers me the
uneaten pieces on her plate.
I've realized she only eats dinner when I suggest it.
I wonder what she does when I'm not there to do so.

Maybe this is why my house feels bigger each time I
return; it's proportional.
As she shrinks the space around her seems increasingly
vast.
She wanes while my father waxes. His stomach has
grown round with wine, late nights, oysters, poetry. A
new girlfriend who was overweight as a teenager, but
my dad reports that now she's "crazy about fruit."

It was the same with his parents;
as my grandmother became frail and angular her
husband swelled to red round cheeks, round stomach
and I wonder if my lineage is one of women shrinking
making space for the entrance of men into their lives
not knowing how to fill it back up once they leave.

I have been taught accommodation.
My brother never thinks before he speaks.
I have been taught to filter.
"How can anyone have a relationship to food?" He asks,
laughing, as I eat the black bean soup I chose for its
lack of carbs.
I want to tell say: we come from difference, Jonas,
you have been taught to grow out
I have been taught to grow in
you learned from our father how to emit, how to
produce, to roll each thought off your tongue with
confidence, you used to lose your voice every other
week from shouting so much
I learned to absorb

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I took lessons from our mother in creating space around
myself
I learned to read the knots in her forehead while the
guys went out for oysters
and I never meant to replicate her, but
spend enough time sitting across from someone and you
pick up their habits

That's why women in my family have been shrinking for
decades.
We all learned it from each other, the way each
generation taught the next how to knit
weaving silence in between the threads
which I can still feel as I walk through this ever-growing
house,
skin itching,
picking up all the habits my mother has unwittingly
dropped like bits of crumpled paper
from her pocket on her countless trips from bedroom to
kitchen to bedroom again,
Nights I hear her creep down to eat plain yogurt in the

dark, a fugitive stealing calories to which she does
not feel entitled.
Deciding how many bites is too many
How much space she deserves to occupy.

Watching the struggle I either mimic or hate her,
And I don't want to do either anymore
but the burden of this house has followed me across the country
I asked five questions in genetics class today and all of them started with the word "sorry".
I don't know the requirements for the sociology major because I spent the entire meeting deciding whether or not I could have another piece of pizza
a circular obsession I never wanted but
inheritance is accidental
still staring at me with wine-stained lips from across the kitchen table.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Lily Myers
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TRANSITION

Once the chains of silence are broken; finding our true voice is fraught with pitfalls. Silenced anger turns inward resulting in lowered self-esteem, self-loathing and a myriad of mental health issues.

Leah Harris is the daughter of two parents who were diagnosed with schizophrenia at an early age. Leah, too, was once a suicidal mental patient who spent most of her adolescence in and out of psychiatric institutions – medicated into silence. Finally at the age of 18, she made the decision to reject the drugs and diagnoses and to strike out on her own – a noncompliant, crazy girl. The following poem was presented at a National Conference on women and psychiatric oppression. Revenge of the Crazy Wimmin by Leah Harris

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Revenge of the Crazy Wimmin

the man's always had a plan
to slow down the velocity of woman's journeys
to lower the volume of woman's voices
saying hush now honey be calm be still
the powers that be saying
there's an appropriate level for your grief and
there's a healthy range for your rage
and when woman exceeds
the emotional speed limit
society put on the brakes

and the more things change
the more they stay
the same
they use the same tactics
but they just change the names

back in the middle ages
they burned unruly women at the stake
and out of the ashes of their bones and flesh

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rose the Enlightenment and Reason fresh
and the white men declared
there's no such thing as witches
they're just crazy psycho-bitches
but we certainly can't let them run free
lock 'em up and throw away the key
yeah they said: lock 'em up and throw away the key

cause there's nothing scarier than a woman mad and/or
aware of her own magic
tragic how much violence is done
in the name of science
to ensure our silence

in Victorian times they located suffering in our uterus
in the blood in the soft internal organs
took our pain our righteous rage
they called it "hysteria"
and then Dr. Freud ignored women's horror stories
herstories of abuse and rape and
took a justified hatred of the penis and called it

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envy (he sold more books that way)

what they call paranoia
we call reality hitting us hard
when we name the forces all around
conspiring to keep us down
when we deny the diagnoses of our masters
when we refuse to be sick, defective, diseased,
disordered, disturbed
when we dare to proclaim our humanity
when we accuse ***them*** of insanity
they call it "lack of insight"
into our condition

but we got an insight that'll blind you

we know something about our conditions
and how we came to be confined:
our husbands our kids they wanted our house our money
yeah it's kinda funny how it goes down
we were visionaries who shared our visions with the
wrong people
we were too poor too butch too ugly too far-gone on the
mean streets
we seen *things* nobody should ever have to see
we got raped got beat got tortured by strangers and
the ones who claimed to love us
and when life comes apart at the seams
when the castles of our dreams implode
we chase the needle in search of the next high
put on a skirt, *sleep with* who we have to just to get
by
and when our demons chase us till
we break up
from the pure exhaustion of being alive
and you're lucky if you survive, honey
yeah, you're lucky if you survive

first: there's a diagnosis for every tragedy
then they sign the forms lock us up put us in solitary
shame us call us names tell us we won't amount to
nothing

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wrestle us down to the ground with their male arms
"treat" us -- tie us up naked bruised and shaking
dope us up with their drugs so we can't stand
can't write can't paint can't think can't speak
wrap us in white sheets (when we ain't dead yet)
take our babies from us
lobotomize us sterilize us electroshock us
rape us kill us
saying this is for your own good
this is for your own good
this is for
your own good

this is for all the mamas daughters sisters lovers
friends
who ended up behind bars
and this is for every woman who died alone
in a locked cell
this is for every woman who's ever survived hell
and emerged to tell the tale to her sisters
our voices thick with saliva and blood speaking

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truth my sisters truth my fellow witches unreasonable
women
yes we are "acting out"
cackling at the scourge of normalcy
as defined by the men waging endless war a la 1984
we diagnose them with "mass destruction disorder"
and write out a prescription for the maximum dose of
justice

and out on the horizon
gather the storm-clouds of our retaliation
in a collective conflagration
we are rising up
picking up the scattered pieces of what shattered
building and birthing out new visions for the generations
to come
with our rage of the ages
the force of our breath
we are shaking off death
and taking in life

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the crazy wimmin

gonna have the last laugh someday

and it's gonna be

loud

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

KS State Qualifier

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